SQL FOR DATA ANALYSIS · LESSON 12 OF 15

Window Functions II: Running Totals, LEAD, LAG & Frames

Build time-series analytics in SQL. Use window frames (ROWS BETWEEN) for running totals and moving averages, LAG and LEAD for month-on-month and year-on-year growth, FIRST_VALUE and LAST_VALUE, cumulative percentages, PERCENT_RANK, CUME_DIST and PERCENTILE_CONT, and gaps-and-islands patterns.

SQL class 5–6 · SQL Server 2022, 2026 · Advanced · 130 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Define a window frame with ROWS BETWEEN and explain the default frame when ORDER BY is present
- Calculate running totals, moving averages and cumulative shares
- Compare each row with the previous or next row using LAG and LEAD (MoM, YoY, gaps)
- Use FIRST_VALUE, LAST_VALUE and NTH_VALUE, PERCENT_RANK, CUME_DIST and PERCENTILE_CONT
- Solve streak and gap problems with ROW_NUMBER differences

Datasets used

`superstore_sales.csv` `daily_sales.csv`

Window frames

Inside `OVER`, `ORDER BY` defines the order and an optional **frame** defines *which rows around the current row* the function uses.

```sql
SUM(x) OVER (PARTITION BY p ORDER BY d
             ROWS BETWEEN <start> AND <end>)
```

Frame boundary	Meaning
`UNBOUNDED PRECEDING`	From the first row of the partition
`n PRECEDING`	n rows before the current row
`CURRENT ROW`	The current row
`n FOLLOWING`	n rows after
`UNBOUNDED FOLLOWING`	To the last row of the partition



Frames relative to the current row (highlighted). A running total uses everything up to the current row; a 3-row moving average uses the previous two rows plus the current one.

COMMON MISTAKES

The default frame trap

When `ORDER BY` is present and no frame is written, SQL Server uses `RANGE BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW`. `RANGE` treats rows with the **same ORDER BY value** as peers and includes them all, which gives surprising results with ties, and `LAST_VALUE` then returns the current row's value. For running totals always write `ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW` explicitly; it is also much faster.

Running totals

First build the monthly sales table, then add a running (cumulative) total and a share:

SQL

```sql
WITH monthly AS (
    SELECT YEAR(order_date) AS yr, MONTH(order_date) AS mth, SUM(sales) AS sales
    FROM superstore
    GROUP BY YEAR(order_date), MONTH(order_date)
)
SELECT yr, mth,
       ROUND(sales, 0) AS sales,
       ROUND(SUM(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY yr ORDER BY mth
                              ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW), 0) AS
ytd_sales,
       ROUND(100.0 * SUM(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY yr ORDER BY mth
                              ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW)
                  / SUM(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY yr), 1)                          AS
ytd_pct_of_year
FROM monthly
ORDER BY yr, mth;
```

RESULT

yr	mth	sales	ytd_sales	ytd_pct_of_year
2023	1	2,447,151	2,447,151	4.2
2023	2	3,861,852	6,309,002	10.9
2023	3	3,441,306	9,750,308	16.9
2023	4	3,927,557	13,677,865	23.7
2023	5	4,840,130	18,517,994	32.1
2023	6	5,785,712	24,303,706	42.2
2023	7	5,390,409	29,694,115	51.5
2023	8	4,129,386	33,823,500	58.7
2023	9	5,714,731	39,538,231	68.6
2023	10	5,134,331	44,672,561	77.5
2023	11	5,815,308	50,487,869	87.6
2023	12	7,152,348	57,640,217	100.0
2024	1	6,022,738	6,022,738	9.2
2024	2	2,463,147	8,485,885	13.0

36 rows × 5 columns (first 14 shown)

`PARTITION BY yr` restarts the running total every January (year-to-date). The percentage uses a second window (the whole year) as the denominator.

Moving averages

A moving average smooths noisy data and shows the trend. Here is the 7-day average of daily units sold:

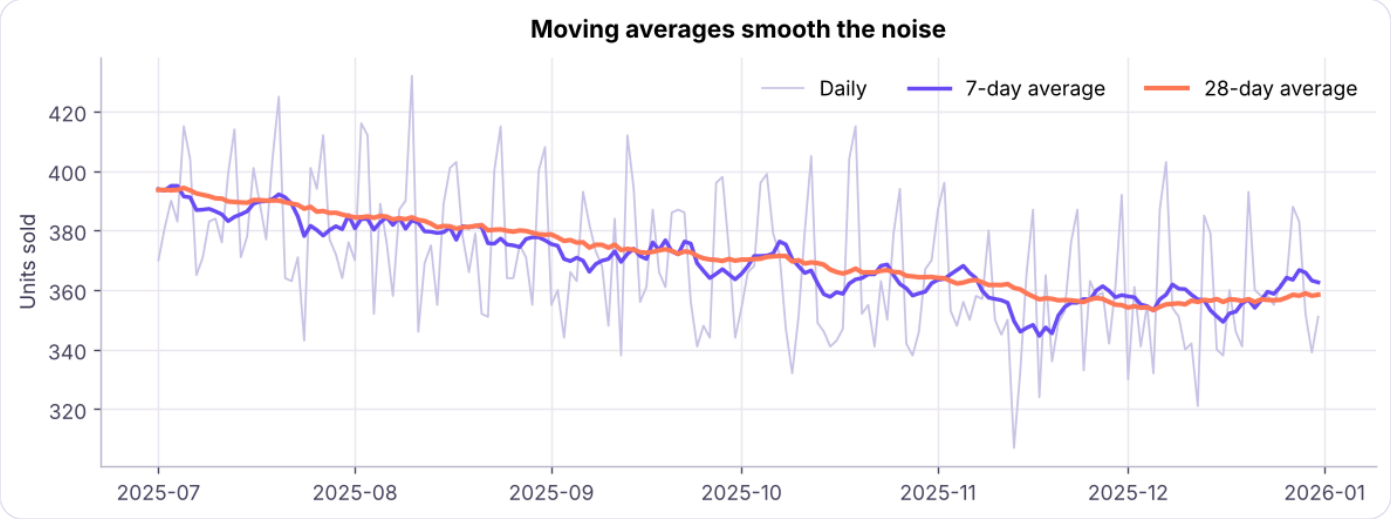
SQL

```sql
SELECT date, units_sold,
       ROUND(AVG(units_sold * 1.0) OVER (ORDER BY date ROWS BETWEEN 6 PRECEDING AND CURRENT
ROW), 1) AS avg_7_day
FROM daily_sales
WHERE date ⩾ '2025-11-01'
ORDER BY date;
```

RESULT

date	units_sold	avg_7_day
2025-11-01	387	387.0
2025-11-02	396	391.5
2025-11-03	353	378.7
2025-11-04	348	371.0
2025-11-05	356	368.0
2025-11-06	350	365.0
2025-11-07	358	364.0
2025-11-08	357	359.7

61 rows × 3 columns (first 8 shown)



Daily units sold and the 7-day and 28-day moving averages (last 6 months of 2025). The weekly pattern (weekend peaks) disappears in the averages; the 28-day line shows the trend.

The first six rows of a 7-row window have fewer than seven rows available: SQL averages whatever exists (partial windows). Check `COUNT(*) OVER (...)` if you need to exclude them.

LAG and LEAD: compare with previous and next rows

Function	Returns
`LAG(col, n, default)`	The value n rows **before** the current row (default n = 1)
`LEAD(col, n, default)`	The value n rows **after**

SQL

```
WITH monthly AS (
    SELECT YEAR(order_date) * 100 + MONTH(order_date) AS ym, SUM(sales) AS sales
    FROM superstore
    GROUP BY YEAR(order_date) * 100 + MONTH(order_date)
)
SELECT ym,
       ROUND(sales, 0)                                                    AS sales,
       ROUND(LAG(sales)  OVER (ORDER BY ym), 0)                           AS prev_month,
       ROUND(100.0 * (sales - LAG(sales) OVER (ORDER BY ym)) / LAG(sales) OVER (ORDER BY
ym), 1) AS mom_pct,
       ROUND(LAG(sales, 12) OVER (ORDER BY ym), 0)                        AS
same_month_last_year,
       ROUND(100.0 * (sales - LAG(sales, 12) OVER (ORDER BY ym)) / LAG(sales, 12) OVER
(ORDER BY ym), 1) AS yoy_pct,
       ROUND(LEAD(sales) OVER (ORDER BY ym), 0)                           AS next_month
FROM monthly
ORDER BY ym;
```

RESULT

ym	sales	prev_month	mom_pct	same_month_last_year	yoy_pct	next_mor
202301	2,447,151	NULL	NULL	NULL	NULL	3,861,85
202302	3,861,852	2,447,151	57.8	NULL	NULL	3,441,30
202303	3,441,306	3,861,852	-10.9	NULL	NULL	3,927,55
202304	3,927,557	3,441,306	14.1	NULL	NULL	4,840,13
202305	4,840,130	3,927,557	23.2	NULL	NULL	5,785,71
202306	5,785,712	4,840,130	19.5	NULL	NULL	5,390,40
202307	5,390,409	5,785,712	-6.8	NULL	NULL	4,129,38
202308	4,129,386	5,390,409	-23.4	NULL	NULL	5,714,73
202309	5,714,731	4,129,386	38.4	NULL	NULL	5,134,33
202310	5,134,331	5,714,731	-10.2	NULL	NULL	5,815,30
202311	5,815,308	5,134,331	13.3	NULL	NULL	7,152,34
202312	7,152,348	5,815,308	23.0	NULL	NULL	6,022,73

36 rows × 7 columns (first 12 shown)

- **MoM** compares with `LAG(sales, 1)`; **YoY** compares with `LAG(sales, 12)` when there is exactly one row per month. This is the SQL equivalent of the pivot table's "Difference From" settings (Excel Lesson 8).
- The first row has no previous value, so `LAG` returns NULL (or the default you supply: `LAG(sales, 1, 0)`).

WATCH OUT **Gaps in the data**

`LAG(sales, 12)` assumes every month exists. If a month has no sales it also has no row, so LAG(12) points at the wrong month. Build a calendar table (a list of every month) and LEFT JOIN the sales onto it first.

Time between events

"How many days passed between each customer's consecutive orders?"

SQL

```sql
WITH o AS (
    SELECT customer_id, order_date,
           LAG(order_date) OVER (PARTITION BY customer_id ORDER BY order_date) AS
prev_order
    FROM orders
)
SELECT COUNT(*)                                          AS repeat_orders,
       ROUND(AVG(DATEDIFF(day, prev_order, order_date) * 1.0), 1) AS
avg_days_between_orders,
       MIN(DATEDIFF(day, prev_order, order_date))        AS shortest_gap,
       MAX(DATEDIFF(day, prev_order, order_date))        AS longest_gap
FROM o
WHERE prev_order IS NOT NULL;
```

RESULT

repeat_orders	avg_days_between_orders	shortest_gap	longest_gap
2415	186.6	0	1001

1 rows × 4 columns

FIRST_VALUE, LAST_VALUE, NTH_VALUE

SQL

```sql
SELECT department, emp_id, monthly_income,
       FIRST_VALUE(emp_id) OVER (PARTITION BY department ORDER BY monthly_income DESC)
AS top_earner,
       LAST_VALUE(emp_id)  OVER (PARTITION BY department ORDER BY monthly_income DESC
                                 ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND UNBOUNDED FOLLOWING)
AS lowest_earner,
       monthly_income - FIRST_VALUE(monthly_income) OVER (PARTITION BY department ORDER BY
monthly_income DESC) AS gap_to_top
FROM employees
ORDER BY department, monthly_income DESC;
```

RESULT

department	emp_id	monthly_income	top_earner	lowest_earner	gap_to_top
Finance	E00519	209833	E00519	E00322	0
Finance	E00145	185500	E00519	E00322	-24333
Finance	E00336	174417	E00519	E00322	-35416
Finance	E00201	169500	E00519	E00322	-40333
Finance	E01172	168167	E00519	E00322	-41666
Finance	E01151	155167	E00519	E00322	-54666
Finance	E00759	152083	E00519	E00322	-57750
Finance	E01004	144667	E00519	E00322	-65166

1,500 rows × 6 columns (first 8 shown)

`LAST_VALUE` needs the explicit full frame (`UNBOUNDED FOLLOWING`); with the default frame it just returns the current row.

Distribution functions

Function	Meaning
`PERCENT_RANK()`	(rank − 1) ÷ (rows − 1): 0 for the lowest, 1 for the highest
`CUME_DIST()`	Share of rows with a value ≤ the current one
`PERCENTILE_CONT(p) WITHIN GROUP (ORDER BY x) OVER (…)`	Interpolated percentile (e.g. median at p = 0.5)
`PERCENTILE_DISC(p) …`	An actual value from the data

SQL

```sql
SELECT DISTINCT department,
       ROUND(PERCENTILE_CONT(0.5) WITHIN GROUP (ORDER BY monthly_income) OVER (PARTITION BY
department), 0) AS median_income,
       ROUND(AVG(monthly_income) OVER (PARTITION BY department), 0)
AS mean_income
FROM employees
ORDER BY department;
```

RESULT

department	median_income	mean_income
Finance	77,709	83,681
HR	86,833	87,805
IT	68,750	79,051
Operations	92,667	92,461
R&D	70,250	80,255
Sales	74,709	82,448

6 rows × 3 columns

In SQL Server, `PERCENTILE_CONT` is a window function (needs `OVER`); PostgreSQL uses it as an aggregate (`GROUP BY`). Mean above median is the signature of a right-skewed distribution (Statistics, ML track).

Cumulative share: the Pareto in SQL

Which products produce the first 80% of sales?

SQL

```sql
WITH p AS (
    SELECT product_id, SUM(sales) AS sales FROM order_items GROUP BY product_id
), c AS (
    SELECT product_id, sales,
           SUM(sales) OVER (ORDER BY sales DESC ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND
CURRENT ROW) * 1.0 / SUM(sales) OVER () AS cum_share,
           ROW_NUMBER() OVER (ORDER BY sales DESC) AS rnk
    FROM p
)
SELECT COUNT(*) AS products_for_80pct_of_sales,
       (SELECT COUNT(*) FROM p)  AS total_products
FROM c
WHERE cum_share ⩽ 0.8;
```

RESULT

products_for_80pct_of_sales	total_products
20	78

1 rows × 2 columns

Gaps and islands: streaks

A classic: find runs of consecutive days. The trick is that `date - ROW_NUMBER()` is **constant within a streak**.

SQL

```sql
WITH days AS (
    SELECT DISTINCT order_date AS d FROM orders WHERE order_date ⩾ '2025-12-01'
), g AS (
    SELECT d, DATEADD(day, -ROW_NUMBER() OVER (ORDER BY d), d) AS grp FROM days
)
SELECT MIN(d) AS streak_start, MAX(d) AS streak_end, COUNT(*) AS days_in_streak
FROM g
GROUP BY grp
ORDER BY streak_start;
```

RESULT

streak_start	streak_end	days_in_streak
2025-12-01	2025-12-31	31

1 rows × 3 columns

Each group of consecutive order days becomes one row: all of December 2025 had orders every day, so there is a single streak. The same pattern finds consecutive login days, uninterrupted employment spells and missing-sequence ranges.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Frames** (`ROWS BETWEEN … AND …`) choose the rows around the current row; always write `ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW` for running totals (the default RANGE frame includes ties).
- Running totals, YTD, cumulative % and moving averages use aggregate functions with frames.
- `LAG`/`LEAD` read the previous/next row (MoM, YoY, time between events); fill calendar gaps first.
- `FIRST_VALUE`/`LAST_VALUE` need an explicit full frame for LAST_VALUE.
- `PERCENT_RANK`, `CUME_DIST`, `PERCENTILE_CONT` describe position and median within a distribution.
- Gaps and islands: `value - ROW_NUMBER()` is constant within a consecutive run.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Which frame gives a 3-month moving average (current and two previous rows)?

A `ROWS BETWEEN 3 PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW`

B `ROWS BETWEEN 2 PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW`

C `ROWS BETWEEN CURRENT ROW AND 2 FOLLOWING`

D `RANGE 3`

Answer: B. Two preceding rows plus the current row make three rows.

2. What does `LAG(sales, 12) OVER (ORDER BY ym)` return for monthly data?

A Sales 12 months in the future

B Sales for the same month last year (if no month is missing)

C The 12th highest sales

D The average of 12 months

Answer: B. LAG reads n rows back; with one row per month that is 12 months earlier.

3. Why does LAST_VALUE often return the current row's value?

A The default frame ends at the current row, so you must extend it to UNBOUNDED FOLLOWING

B LAST_VALUE is broken in SQL Server

C It only works with PARTITION BY

D ORDER BY is missing

Answer: A. Specify ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND UNBOUNDED FOLLOWING.

4. How do you restart a running total every year?

A ORDER BY year

B PARTITION BY year in the OVER clause

C GROUP BY year only

D Use LAG

Answer: B. Each partition has its own running total.

5. In the gaps-and-islands trick, what stays constant inside a streak of consecutive dates?

A The date

B The row number

C The date minus its ROW_NUMBER

D The count

Answer: C. Both increase by 1 per row, so their difference is constant.

6. **Mean income is much higher than median income. What does that suggest?**

A Symmetric data

B A right-skewed distribution with a few very high values

C Missing data

D A data error

Answer: B. A long right tail pulls the mean above the median.

EXERCISE

Time-series practice

(1) Monthly sales per region with MoM %; (2) for each customer, the days since their previous order and a flag for "returned within 30 days"; (3) a 3-month moving average of sales by category; (4) the month when cumulative 2025 sales first exceeded ₹5 crore.

Show solution (worked answer)

SQL

```sql
-- (1)
WITH m AS (SELECT region, YEAR(order_date)*100+MONTH(order_date) AS ym, SUM(sales) AS
sales FROM superstore GROUP BY region, YEAR(order_date)*100+MONTH(order_date))
SELECT region, ym, ROUND(sales,0) AS sales,
       ROUND(100.0*(sales - LAG(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY region ORDER BY ym)) /
LAG(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY region ORDER BY ym), 1) AS mom_pct FROM m ORDER BY
region, ym;
-- (2)
WITH o AS (SELECT customer_id, order_date, LAG(order_date) OVER (PARTITION BY
customer_id ORDER BY order_date) AS prev FROM orders)
SELECT customer_id, order_date, DATEDIFF(day, prev, order_date) AS days_since_prev,
       CASE WHEN DATEDIFF(day, prev, order_date) <= 30 THEN 1 ELSE 0 END AS
within_30_days FROM o WHERE prev IS NOT NULL;
-- (3)
WITH m AS (SELECT category, YEAR(order_date)*100+MONTH(order_date) AS ym, SUM(sales)
AS sales FROM superstore GROUP BY category, YEAR(order_date)*100+MONTH(order_date))
SELECT category, ym, AVG(sales) OVER (PARTITION BY category ORDER BY ym ROWS BETWEEN 2
PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW) AS ma3 FROM m;
-- (4)
WITH m AS (SELECT MONTH(order_date) AS mth, SUM(sales) AS sales FROM superstore WHERE
YEAR(order_date) = 2025 GROUP BY MONTH(order_date)),
     c AS (SELECT mth, SUM(sales) OVER (ORDER BY mth ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING
AND CURRENT ROW) AS cum FROM m)
SELECT TOP 1 mth FROM c WHERE cum > 50000000 ORDER BY mth;
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: How do you calculate a running total in SQL? `SUM(x) OVER (ORDER BY d ROWS BETWEEN UNBOUNDED PRECEDING AND CURRENT ROW)`, optionally partitioned.

Q: How do you calculate month-on-month growth? Aggregate to months, then `(sales - LAG(sales) OVER (ORDER BY month)) / LAG(sales) OVER (ORDER BY month)`; use `LAG(…, 12)` for YoY.

Q: ROWS vs RANGE in a window frame? ROWS counts physical rows; RANGE includes all rows with the same ORDER BY value as the current row (peers). ROWS is predictable and faster.

Q: How would you find consecutive login days? Gaps and islands: `date - ROW_NUMBER() OVER (PARTITION BY user ORDER BY date)` as a group key, then GROUP BY it.

Practise more online

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